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Justice and judgment among the Tiv

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Section Title(S): III. THE SUBJECTS OF THE MOOT

This moot, like most others, began about noon. The elders sat about chatting and joking. The women, much more quietly, also talked among themselves, and allocated the work which they would do during the course of the moot—picking the seeds from cotton, spinning, removing the husks from gourd seeds.

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Uta, who was impatient, began the *jir* by shouting at Akusa, 'Akusa, why have you called us together?'

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The crowd became still as Akusa answered, 'Sleep is not good to me' (*Myav doom ga*).

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Fiyase took up the questioning, 'What is it?'

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Akusa replied, 'Something is hurting my mother and I have called my lineage together to tell them that she is ill. I will not eat her alone.' The last was a reference to the fact that if he did not invite his agnatic lineage together to discuss her fate, he would be held responsible for her death.

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Fiyase asked, 'What did the diviner say?'

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Akusa replied, 'I have not consulted a diviner.' This reply could have meant either that he did not do it himself, or that no one had done it.

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Fiyase turned to Anyam, Akusa's half-brother and asked, 'Who went to the diviner?'

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Anyam replied that he did not know—he had not been asked to go and, since it was neither his mother nor his ward, he was not concerned. [Had he gone to a diviner without being requested, he would have been guilty of interfering and would probably have been charged with being over-solicitous and therefore in some way implicated.]

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Fiyase made a show of anger. 'What do you mean,' he railed at Akusa, 'calling us together to discuss the matter of your mother when you have not been to a diviner so that we shall know what needs discussing?'

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Fiyase threatened to leave immediately, but the women raised such a shout that he made no move to go. The elders began to ask questions about

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Material Not Relevant

the exchange marriage. MbaCie's exchange partner had died in MbaDigam, and at that time MbaDigam had come to 'ask',¹ and soon thereafter sores broke out on MbaCie's legs. But this matter was taken care of by her husband and it was finished. The number of children born to each of the two marriages was approximately equal, and the exchange was finished.

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i.e. to 'ask' the girl's agnatic lineage why they had 'killed our wife'.

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